

# Recommendations for a U.S. Caribbean Funding Governance Structure

## Summary

A primary goal of the Southeast Fisheries Science Center's (SEFSC) Caribbean Strategic Planning project is to establish an equitable funding governance structure for the U.S. Caribbean. The first step in accomplishing that goal is to define the needs and identify the mechanisms for establishing a funding governance structure. A working group was established to define the who, what, why, and where of current funding in the U.S. Caribbean, create conceptual models of current funding structures and collaborations including the transfers, pipelines, and bottlenecks, and benchmark other regional funding mechanisms that address bottlenecks. This document contains those findings.



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## Acronyms

| <i>Acronym</i> | <i>Definition</i>                                                                                        |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CCC            | Council Coordination Committee                                                                           |
| CFMC           | Caribbean Fishery Management Council                                                                     |
| CIMAS          | Cooperative Institute for Marine and Atmospheric Studies                                                 |
| CRCP           | Coral Reef Conservation Program                                                                          |
| CRP            | Cooperative Research Program                                                                             |
| CSP            | Cooperative Statistics Program                                                                           |
| FIN            | Fisheries Information Network                                                                            |
| GSMFC          | Gulf States Marine Fisheries Commission                                                                  |
| MARFIN         | Marine Fisheries Initiative                                                                              |
| MOU            | Memorandum of Understanding                                                                              |
| MRIP           | Marine Recreational Information Program                                                                  |
| NOAA           | National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration                                                          |
| NOS            | National Ocean Service                                                                                   |
| NMFS           | National Marine Fisheries Service                                                                        |
| NPS            | National Park Service                                                                                    |
| OAR            | Office of Oceanic and Atmospheric Research                                                               |
| OMB            | Office of Management and Budget                                                                          |
| OST            | Office of Science and Technology                                                                         |
| RFP            | Request for Proposal                                                                                     |
| PR             | Puerto Rico                                                                                              |
| PR DRNA        | Puerto Rico Departamento de Recursos Naturales y Ambientales                                             |
| SEAMAP-C       | Southeast Area Monitoring and Assessment Program - Caribbean                                             |
| SEFSC          | Southeast Fisheries Science Center                                                                       |
| SERO           | Southeast Regional Office                                                                                |
| SK             | Saltonstall-Kennedy                                                                                      |
| UPR            | University of Puerto Rico                                                                                |
| USVI           | United States Virgin Islands                                                                             |
| USVI DPNR DFW  | United States Virgin Islands Department of Planning and Natural Resources, Division of Fish and Wildlife |

## Working Group

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Please contact a working group member with changes or suggestions.

## Introduction

Governance of funds to support Caribbean fisheries initiatives is a convoluted process due to competing priorities and agencies. Federal funds are often dispersed to science centers late in the fiscal year and have a short spending timeframe, which results in delays in performing necessary research to inform fisheries management. The process to solicit federal and jurisdictional contracts is lengthy and laborious, further delaying research efforts. While some limited avenues for transferring federal funds to Territorial and Commonwealth governments (PR DRNA or USVI DPNR DFW) exist, once federal funds are received, the jurisdictions have additional administrative requirements and contractual roadblocks for spending research funds and for establishing contracts with independent researchers and fishers which can take years to process. The U.S. Caribbean is not covered by any US Fishery Commission, which creates an administrative burden for Puerto Rico and the U.S. Virgin Islands that is not shared by any other state in the U.S. In order to advance Caribbean fisheries stock assessment efforts, there is a need to establish more reasonable and equitable funding governance structures to ensure research funding can be easily distributed and spent.

Participants volunteered to join this strategic planning working group to achieve the first few steps of establishing a funding governance structure. During the initial meeting of the group, the participants developed their purpose, goals, and ideal outcomes, which are documented in the [Team Charter](#). The group met 33 times over the course of three years to accomplish the goals. Section A contains those goals and what was accomplished under each goal. Section B builds on the accomplished goals and contains general paint points and Section C contains recommendations to establish a balanced funding governance structure.

## A. Goals & Summary of Actions to Address Goals:

The goals of the project and specific steps taken to address the goals are:

1. Define the who, what, why, and where of current funding in the U.S. Caribbean

Group discussion and conversations with funding program coordinators and PR DRNA or USVI DPNR DFW led to the identification of major funding programs and avenues for dispersing research funds in the U.S. Caribbean (Table 1).

Table 1. List of the major funding sources and pathways to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

| <i>Program Title</i> | <i>Funding Source</i> | <i>POC</i>                                                                                                | <i>Type</i>            |
|----------------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| CFMC                 | Federal Appropriation | María de los Ángeles Irizarry<br><a href="mailto:mairizarry_cfmc@yahoo.com">mairizarry_cfmc@yahoo.com</a> | Council                |
| CIMAS                | NOAA                  | Luis Quijada<br><a href="mailto:lcq5@miami.edu">lcq5@miami.edu</a>                                        | Cooperative Institute  |
| CRCP                 | NOAA                  | Tauna Rankin<br><a href="mailto:tauna.rankin@noaa.gov">tauna.rankin@noaa.gov</a>                          | Programmatic and Grant |
| CRP                  | NOAA                  | Dax Ruiz<br><a href="mailto:dax.ruiz@noaa.gov">dax.ruiz@noaa.gov</a>                                      | Grant                  |
| CSP                  | NOAA                  | Kim Raneses<br><a href="mailto:kim.raneses@noaa.gov">kim.raneses@noaa.gov</a>                             | Grant                  |
| Federal Grant        | NOAA                  | Varied                                                                                                    | Grant                  |

2. Create conceptual models of current funding structures and collaborations including the transfers, pipelines, and bottlenecks

Flow diagrams of current funding transfers for the entities and avenues identified in Table 1 were developed using Microsoft Visio. The flow diagrams display transfers of funding, processes and authority, and products and services as well as identify the sources and recipients of the funds. Bottlenecks and pain points in the processes are also indicated on the flow diagrams by the red numbered Xs. Working group members created each flow diagram with their current understanding of the governance structure and funding flow process. To ensure accuracy, the diagrams were then shown to SEFSC and NMFS budget analysts and financial officers and members of the organizations to identify errors and propose necessary edits. The edited flow diagrams can be seen in Figures 1-6. While the working group aimed to be as thorough as possible, the completeness of the flow diagrams and identification of pain points may benefit from additional critical review of experts beyond the members of this working group.

## CFMC

The Caribbean Fishery Management Council is one of eight regional fishery management councils, established under the Magnuson-Stevens Fishery Conservation and Management Act for the conservation and orderly utilization of the fishery resources in the U.S. Caribbean. Federal funds are distributed from Congress, transferred through the CCC, to the CFMC (Figure 1). The CFMC's Executive Committee sets the five-year budget. Funds are then distributed to Territorial and Commonwealth liaisons or contractors or awarded as cooperative agreements to academic institutions or contractors to support critical research.

The pain points are: X1. Specialty funds were combined with base funding; X2. A new platform for managing contracts was recently introduced; X3. Funding can only be distributed to contractors rather than PR DRNA or USVI DPNR DFW, except for certain specialty funds; X4. CFMC members do not set the budget; X5. The CFMC approves the budget and pays contractors directly; and X6. Ecosystem-Based Fisheries Management funding restrictions.

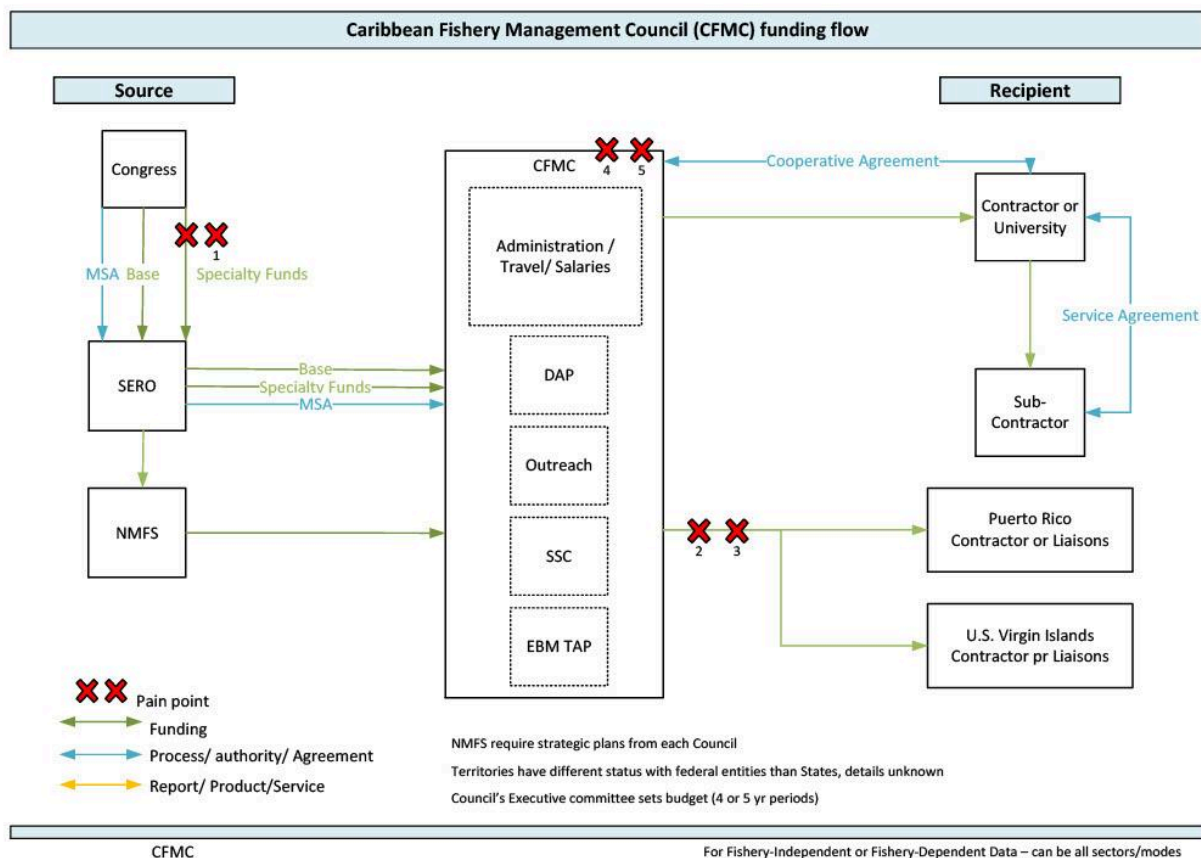


Figure 1. Funding flow diagram, with pain points, for the Caribbean Fishery Management Council to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

## CIMAS

The Cooperative Institute for Marine and Atmospheric Studies is a federally supported institute, located at the University of Miami's Rosenstiel School of Marine, Atmospheric, and Earth Science, that brings together the research and educational resources of ten partner universities to provide research opportunities, educational training, and outreach to students and postdoctoral scientists in NOAA-funded research. Federal funds are distributed from NOAA OAR and transferred through the SEFSC to CIMAS to fund fisheries-related research and hire NOAA Affiliates (Figure 2). Task I funds cover graduate student support with no overhead fees if the hire is a UM student (otherwise 10%). Task II funds are used for salaried affiliate hires, with a current fringe rate of 36.5%, affiliate travel, invitational travel, and research supplies. The indirect cost rate is 26% and transfer fee is 2.7%. Task III funds are used for non-CIMAS researchers in the form of a subcontract or subaward. The indirect cost rate is applied to the whole subcontract or the first \$25k of the sub-award and the rate depends on whether the research occurs on or off UM campus. All rates are subject to change annually.

The pain points are: X1. Allocation amount and delivery date are uncertain and base funding and grant money can be moved to CIMAS; X2. Limited NMFS Head Quarters budgeting staff causes delays; X3. Challenging and lengthy hiring process for Task I; X4. More challenging and lengthy hiring process for Task II; X5. More challenging and lengthy process for Task III subawards and hiring researchers; and X6. More challenging and lengthy process for hiring Task III non-CIMAS researchers.

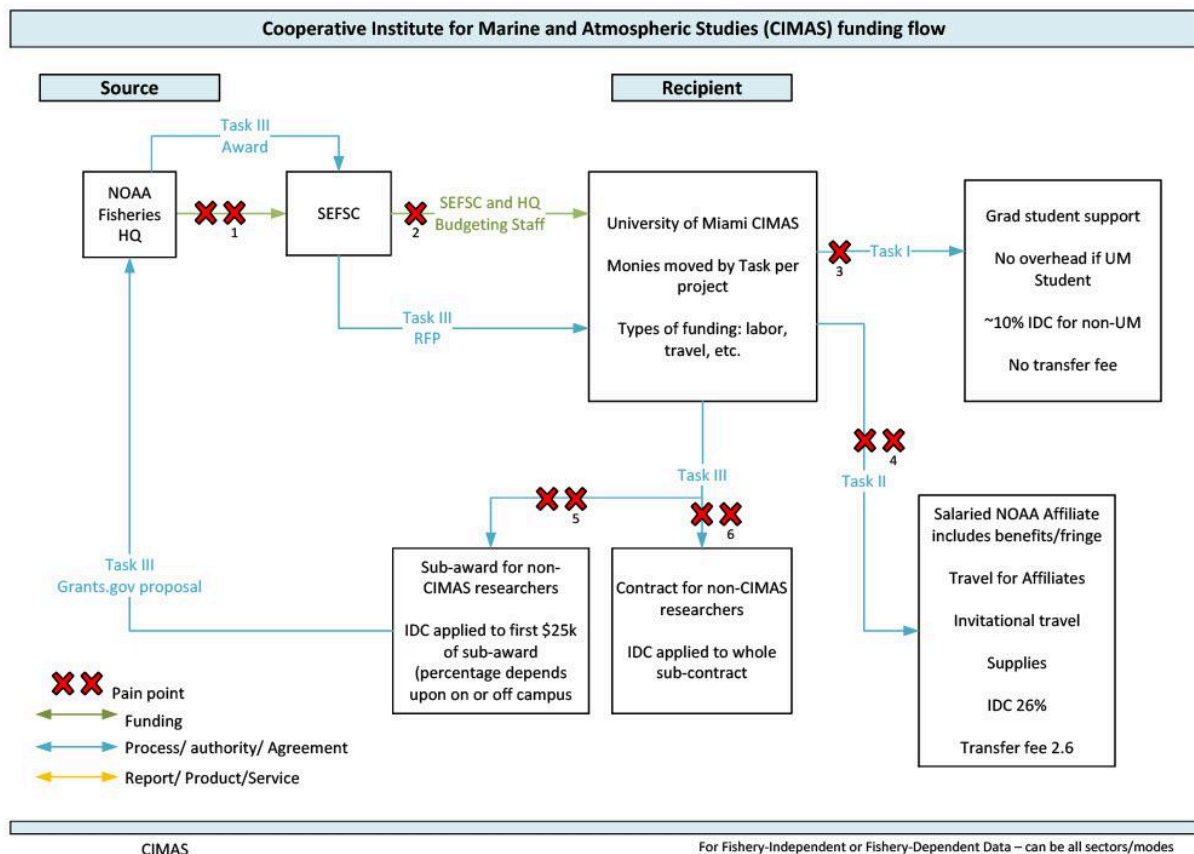


Figure 2. Funding flow diagram, with pain points, for the Cooperative Institute for Marine and Atmospheric Studies to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.



## CRCP

The Coral Reef Conservation Program issues wide-ranging funds to both internal NOAA line offices and external recipients to support coral reef ecosystem research for the protection, conservation, and restoration of healthy coral reefs. Funds are distributed from NOS and transferred through the NOAA line offices to the National Program or to industry participants and scientific personnel as Cooperative Agreements to support critical research (Figure 3). Funds from the National Program can be used to cover federal labor, federal travel, contracts, grants, and CIMAS researchers. Funds from NOS can also be transferred directly to Territorial and Commonwealth governments as State Block Grants to fund contractors.

The pain points are: X1. NOAA has limited ability to guide grants and ensure that grantees work together and don't duplicate effort; X2. This funding opportunity ends in FY26; What is likely to replace it is a broader coral reef fisheries management opportunity that will be open to more eligible applicants than just four fishery management councils (Caribbean, Gulf, South Atlantic, and Western Pacific); X3. Subcontracting the work adds delays to getting the results back and making them publicly available; X4. Block Grants are authorized at \$8M in the Coral Reef Conservation Act, but NOAA CRCP hasn't received the full appropriation yet to fully fund these; X5. Subcontracting the work adds delays to starting the work and getting the results back and making them publicly available; X6. The Line Offices have different missions and perspectives on priorities, and X7. Funds are diverted from their intended purpose. The Matrix Management nature means more decision-making hoops to jump through.

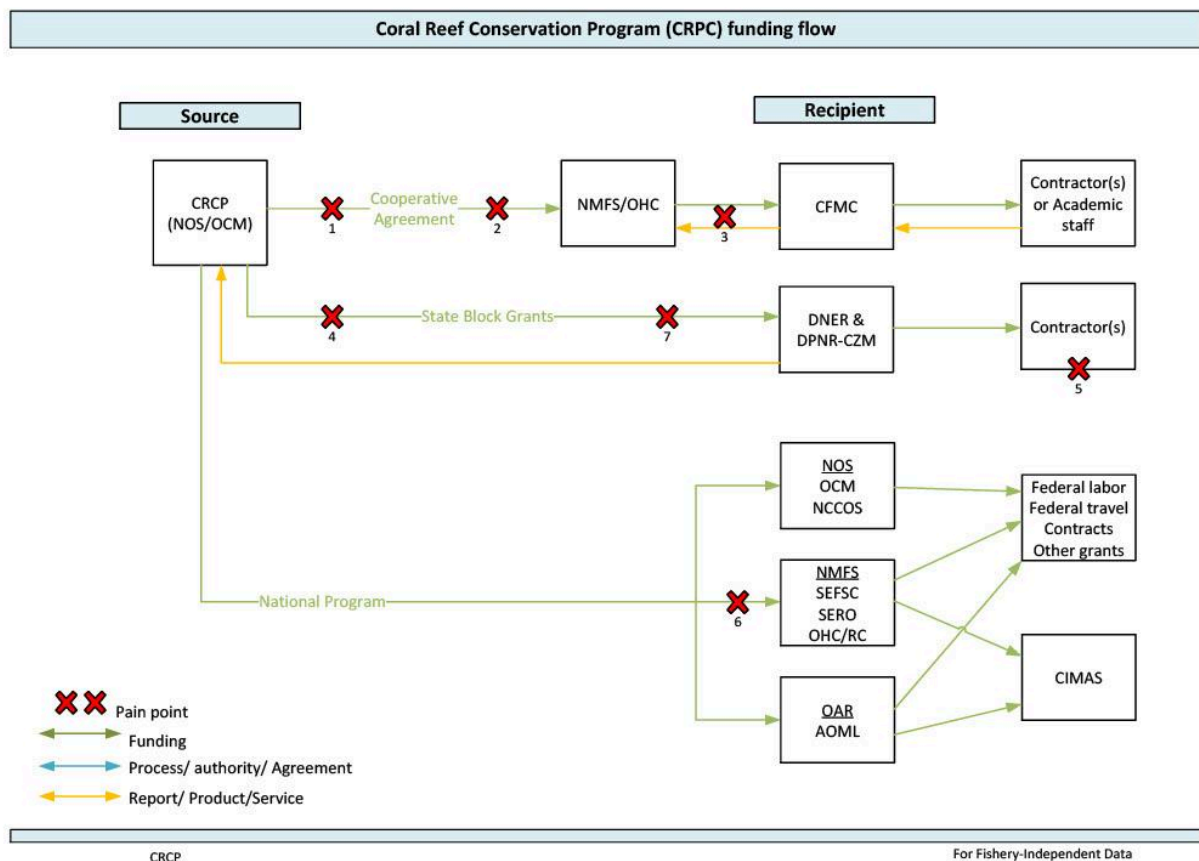


Figure 3. Funding flow diagram, with pain points, for the Coral Reef Conservation Program to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

## CRP

The Cooperative Research Program of NOAA Fisheries provides a means of involving commercial and recreational fishermen in the collection of fundamental fisheries information to support the development and evaluation of management and regulatory measures. Industry and other stakeholders can partner with NOAA Fisheries and university scientists, in all phases of the research program, including survey/statistical design, conducting research, analyzing results, and communicating results. Federal staff may apply for funds through an internal review process. There is also a separate external-to-NOAA RFP process. In the internal program, federal funds are distributed from NMFS OMB, transferred through SERO and SEFSC, to Territorial and Commonwealth governments and awarded as contracts to industry participants and scientific personnel (Figure 4). Funds can also be transferred directly from SEFSC to contractors or through CIMAS Task II to contractors.

The pain points are: X1. Acquisition restrictions vary among grants and contracts; X2. Internal SEFSC contracting makes it difficult to send the money to governments; X3. Difficult to spend funds (timing issues, low staff, fiscal year differences, pooling multiple funds) and a lengthy process to find a contractor and set up the contract causes delays in paying contractors and further delays paying fishers, scientists, or subcontractors; X4. Difficult to find qualified contractors; X5. Difficult to send money to contractors; X6. Difficult to find industry participants interested in setting up paperwork to accept funds, and then no control over subcontractors; X7. Few to no bids on RFPs - do not have established relationships with contractors or contractors do not want to work with local governments; X8. No legal team to create contracts; and X9. The process is not transparent.

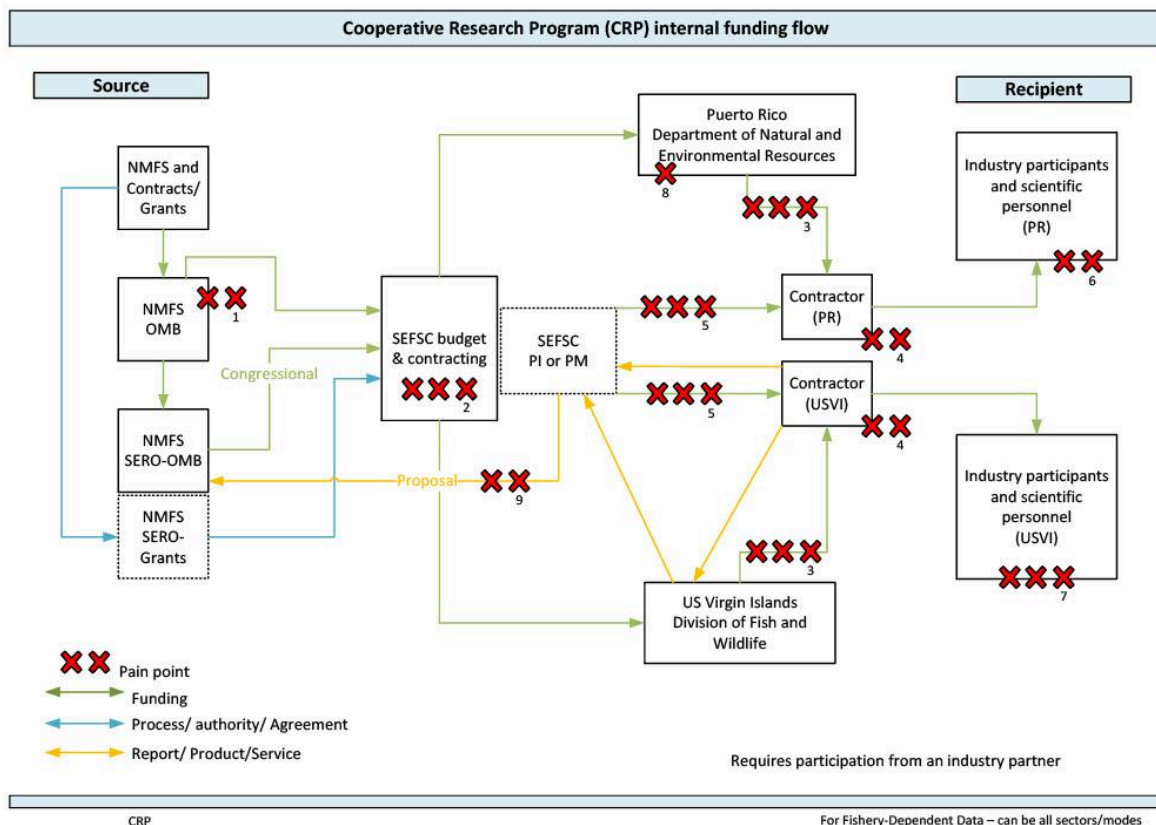


Figure 4. Funding flow diagram, with pain points, for the Cooperative Research Program to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

## CSP

The state-federal Cooperative Statistics Program collects landings data from the commercial and recreational fisheries of the southeast region of the U.S. Federal funds are distributed from NMFS OMB, transferred through SERO, the SEFSC and USVI and PR governments, used as operational funds for the commercial fishery and awarded as contracts to industry participants and scientific personnel in some cases (Figure 5). In Puerto Rico, funds are used for Statement Of Work tasks, Trip Interview Program samplers, data entry staff, and Puerto Rico Shellcatch\* fees.

The pain points are: X1. Timely delivery of funds (bureaucratic steps in congress, before NMFS and SERO); X2. Plus-ups may exceed the agreed funding ceiling and require modification of the agreement; X3. This funding source covers 25% of salaries for data entry and Puerto Rico Shellcatch\* - the SEFSC does not have a say in how the funds are spent; X4. Difficult to spend funds (timing issues, low staff, fiscal year differences, pooling multiple funds) and there is a lengthy process to find a contractor and set up the contract, which causes delays in paying contractors and further delays paying fishers, scientists, or subcontractors; X5. Difficult to find qualified contractors who may or may not be local; and X6. Annual and five-year reports are not standardized and a heavy lift for the USVI and PR staff.

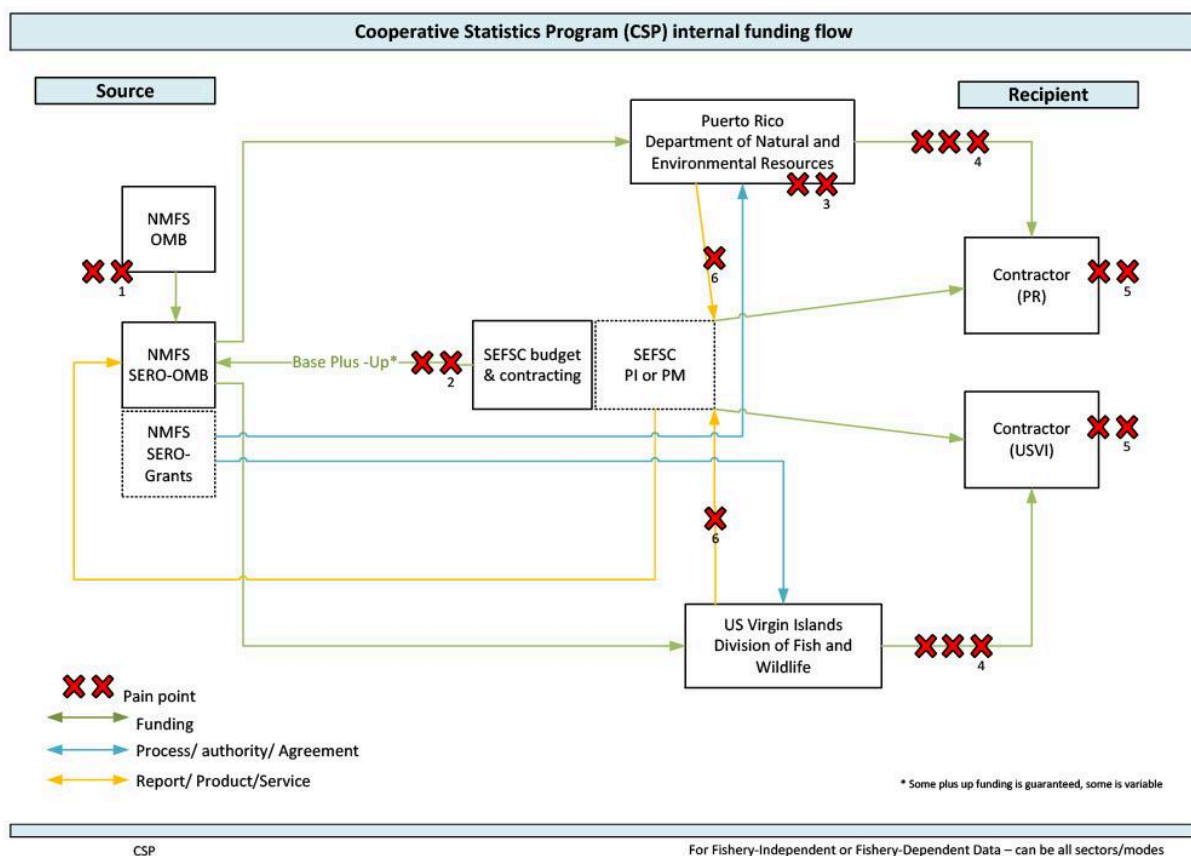


Figure 5. Funding flow diagram, with pain points, for the Cooperative Statistics Program to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

**\*Shellcatch** is an electronic monitoring and reporting platform and mobile application designed to collect and store commercial logbook data in Puerto Rico.

## Federal Grant

Federal grant programs are available to government, nonprofit organizations, for-profit businesses, and other eligible entities, and in the case of fisheries are used for mission critical operations and research. Each applicable federal grant program has an internal officer that manages the funds at the NMFS level. Examples of federal grants include MARFIN and SK. Federal funds are distributed from NMFS OMB, transferred through the SEFSC and the SEFSC and Territorial and Commonwealth governments, and awarded as contracts to industry participants and scientific personnel (Figure 6).

The pain points are: X1. Issues connecting to grants systems (e.g., GEMS eRA); X2. Institutional knowledge lost at SERO during the 2025 reduction in the federal force; X3. Difficult to spend funds (timing issues, low staff, fiscal year differences, pooling multiple funds) and there is a lengthy process to find a contractor and set up the contract, which causes delays in paying contractors and further delays paying fishers, scientists, or subcontractors; X4. Difficult to find qualified contractors who may or may not be local; X5. Difficult to find industry participants - no control over subcontractors; X6. Few to no bids on RFPs, do not have established relationships with contractors; X7. Institutional knowledge lost at SEFSC during the 2025 reduction in the federal force with a reduced lack of knowledge in budget and contracting processes; and X8. Subaward and subcontract processes are viewed by fiscal department as the same process (whereas subaward should be viewed like a grant as a collaborating partner and subcontract should be reserved for hired labor).

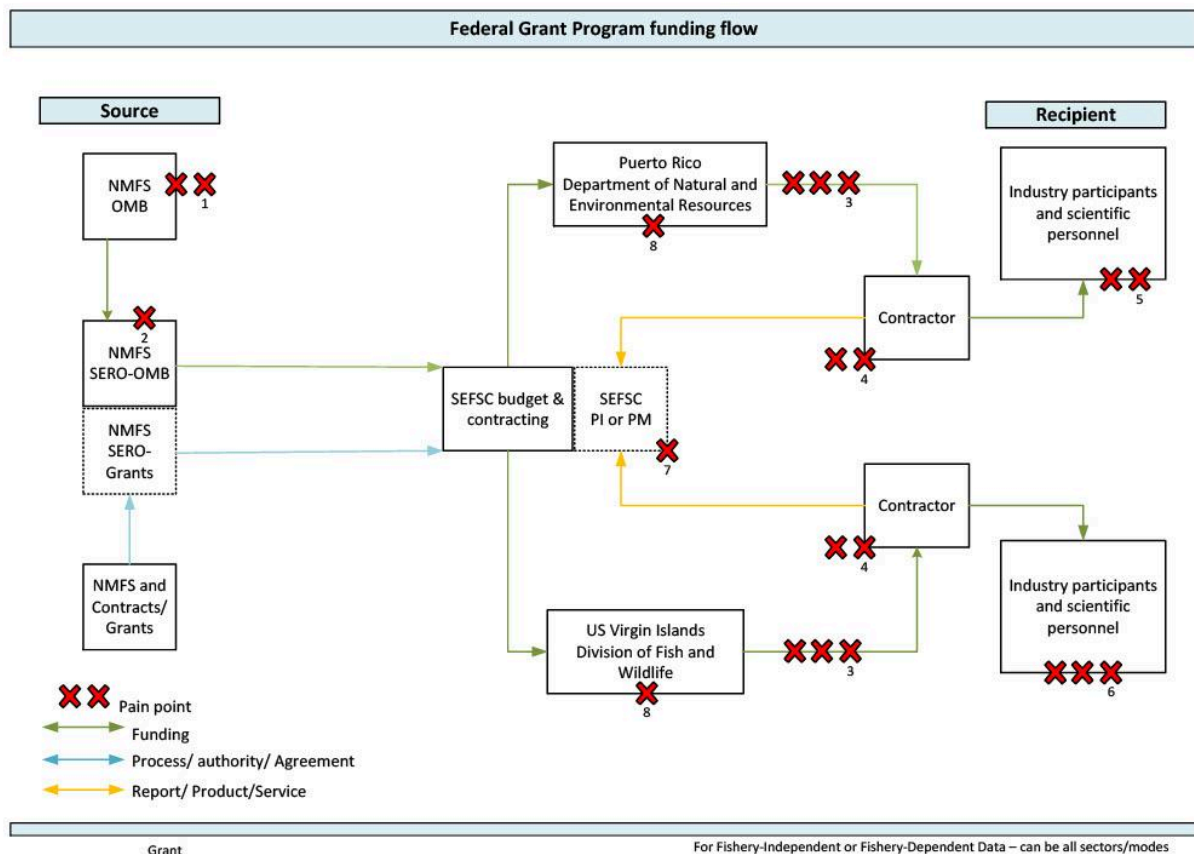


Figure 6. Funding flow diagram, with pain points, for Federal Grant Programs to support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

## **B. General Pain Points for the Current U.S. Caribbean Funding Governance Structure:**

Specific bottlenecks and pain points for the current funding governance structure in U.S. Caribbean fisheries-related research were identified and listed above. Those pain points were condensed and summarized into general pain points listed below in no order of importance.

1. Transparency of project funding and lack of strategic planning
  - a. Funded projects may not support the CFMC's Strategic Plan or Scientific and Statistical Committees' Research Priorities
  - b. Without using the created strategic plans, the CFMC prioritized objectives are left unfunded (e.g., Ecosystem-Based Fisheries Management)
  - c. CFMC council members do not review the CFMC's Executive Director and staff budget
2. Developing and funding projects that align with strategic plans (CFMC, SEFSC, SERO) and research/management priorities (SSC, SEFSC-SERO)
3. Coordination, collaboration, and communication among Principal Investigators
  - a. NOAA has limited ability to guide grants and ensure that grantees work together to reduce duplication of efforts
4. Contracting and subcontracting delays
  - a. Hiring and retention of port samplers (PR DRNA and USVI DPNR DFW)
  - b. Processing at the federal level and delays in receiving the full appropriations in enough time to get contracts in order
  - c. Acquisition restrictions vary among contracts

## **C. Specific Recommendations for a Balanced U.S. Caribbean Funding Governance Structure:**

Specific recommendations to create a balanced funding governance structure that supports needed fisheries related research in the U.S. Caribbean were identified and listed below in no order of importance.

1. Invest time and resources into strategic planning to identify and prioritize research needs
2. Encourage researchers to propose projects that support regional strategic plans and priorities (e.g., CFMC's Strategic Plan, Scientific and Statistical Committees' Research Priorities, Southeast Regional Action Plan, Southeast Geographic Strategic Plan, etc.)
3. Fund research that supports regional strategic plans and priorities
4. Allow CFMC members to review and offer suggestions prior to publishing the CFMC's Executive Committee's budget to ensure funding is available for research that supports regional strategic plans and priorities
5. Establish an effective coordination strategy among SEFSC, SERO, CFMC, PR DRNA, and USVI DPNR DFW, academic partners, and contractors to reduce duplication of research efforts and maximize resource usage (see recommendation 8 related to Commissions)
6. Establish processes that ensure funding is able to efficiently pass from federal sources to USVI and PR governments and contractors to perform research that supports regional strategic plans and priorities

7. Encourage Operations, Management and Information Division at the SEFSC participation in streamlining funding flows to create more efficient processes and alleviate pain points
8. Identify where the U.S. Virgin Islands and Puerto Rico can coordinate with the Fishery Commissions (either Gulf States or Atlantic) to improve roll-out of funding, data consistency, and stock assessments

Additional funding flow diagrams could be produced to better understand funding governance issues in the Caribbean region. For example, Federal or Commonwealth/Territorial Contracts, Cooperative Agreements Interjurisdictional Fisheries Program, Sea Grant, SEAMAP-C, Sportfish Restoration, GulfFIN, and MRIP were identified as entities and potential avenues for funding transfers for necessary fisheries research in the U.S. Caribbean (Table 2). However, the working group members of this project did not have the necessary expertise to define the funding flow processes or fully grasp the pain points and bottlenecks.

1. **Contractors** with NMFS or PR DRNA and USVI DPNR DFW support observational monitoring, data collection, and other research activities. Small businesses are encouraged to become a federal contractor by registering with SAM.gov and following the necessary regulations. Registered businesses can bid on federal contract opportunities. If awarded, federal funds are distributed from NMFS to the contractor directly, to the SEFSC then to the contractor, or are passed through the Territorial and Commonwealth governments to the contractor. Funds from state directives are passed through the Territorial and Commonwealth governments and distributed to the contractor.
2. **Cooperative Agreements** are a legal award of financial assistance between a sponsor and a recipient. In the case of fisheries, cooperative agreements are established between USVI and Commonwealth governments and industry participants and scientific personnel to support critical research. Federal funds are distributed from NOAA, transferred through the SEFSC to industry participants or to Puerto Rico and the USVI as a grant award.
3. The **Interjurisdictional Fisheries Program** was established by congress for interjurisdictional management and research activities, the development of fishery management plans through interstate commissions, fishery resource disaster assistance, and disaster assistance to commercial fishermen. Federal funds are distributed from NOAA and awarded to member states and/or industry participants.
4. The **Gulf Fisheries Information Network** is a state-federal cooperative program among agencies to collect, manage, and disseminate statistical data and information on the commercial fisheries of the Southeast Region. The network is funded through the GSMFC and mandated by an MOU. Federal funds are distributed from NOAA, to the GSMFC, and transferred to the member states to assess stocks, forecast trends, and monitor fishery regulations. The GulfFIN jurisdiction includes the five state agencies that border the Gulf by Congress and the USVI and PR by agreement, although funds are currently not distributed or used to support the U.S. Caribbean.
5. The **Marine Recreational Information Program** was a state-regional-federal partnership that developed, implemented, and improved a national network of recreational fishing surveys to estimate total recreational catch. MRIP's eight Regional Implementation Teams identified information needs and recommendations for programmatic improvements every five years. Federal funds were distributed from NOAA OST, and through SERO or directly to Territorial and Commonwealth governments and awarded as contracts to industry participants and scientific

personnel. In the U.S. Caribbean, MRIP replaced Marine Recreational Fisheries Statistics Survey (MRFSS) in 2008 and ended in 2017. A new program, Recreational Angler Partnership Improvement Directive (RAPID), is being established to build a stronger state-federal recreational data partnership. Future iterations of this workgroup should revisit the RAPID program as a funding pathway once established.

6. **Sea Grant** is a federal-university partnership program between NOAA and 34 university-based programs in every coastal and Great Lakes state, Puerto Rico, and Guam to enhance the use and conservation of coastal, marine and Great Lakes resources to create a strong and sustainable economy, a healthy environment, and resilient and inclusive communities. The Sea Grant program of the Caribbean region is operated through the University of Puerto Rico at the Mayagüez and Humacao campuses. The Sea Grant funding competition is held biannually for fisheries and aquaculture scientific research. Puerto Rico Sea Grant consistently funds a program at the University of the Virgin Islands.
7. **Southeast Area Monitoring and Assessment Program - Caribbean** is a state, federal, and university program for the collection, management, and dissemination of fishery independent data. Federal funds are distributed from NOAA and awarded as contracts to industry participants and scientific personnel.
8. The **Sportfish Restoration Administrative Program** provides funds to fish and wildlife agencies of the states, the District of Columbia, and U.S. territories for recreational fishery projects, boating access, and aquatic education. Taxes on fishing equipment, small engine fuels, and import duties are sent to the program and then distributed to territories based on land and paid license holders.

Table 2. Additional funding sources and pathways that may support operational programs and data collection efforts for fisheries management in the U.S. Caribbean.

| <i>Program Title</i>          | <i>Funding Source</i>        | <i>POC</i>                                                                                                                           | <i>Type</i>           |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| Contracts (SEFSC)             | NOAA                         | Varied                                                                                                                               | Contract              |
| Contracts (PR and USVI)       | NOAA, state directive        | Varied                                                                                                                               | Contract              |
| Cooperative Agreement         | NOAA                         | Varied                                                                                                                               | Cooperative Agreement |
| Interjurisdictional Fisheries | Federal Appropriation        | Kim Raneses<br><a href="mailto:kim.raneses@noaa.gov">kim.raneses@noaa.gov</a>                                                        | Grant                 |
| GulfFIN                       | Federal Appropriation        | Gregg Bray<br><a href="mailto:gbray@gsfmc.org">gbray@gsfmc.org</a>                                                                   | Programmatic*         |
| MRIP/RAPID                    | Federal Appropriation        | Kaitlen Lang<br><a href="mailto:fisheries.pco@noaa.gov">fisheries.pco@noaa.gov</a>                                                   | Programmatic          |
| Sea Grant                     | NOAA                         | Federal: <a href="mailto:sgweb@noaa.gov">sgweb@noaa.gov</a><br>Puerto Rico: <a href="mailto:seagrant@uprm.edu">seagrant@uprm.edu</a> | Grant                 |
| SEAMAP-C                      | Federal Appropriation, GSMFC | Kim Raneses<br><a href="mailto:kim.raneses@noaa.gov">kim.raneses@noaa.gov</a>                                                        | Grant**               |
| Sportfish Restoration Program | FWS                          | Paul Wilkes<br><a href="mailto:paul_wilkes@fws.gov">paul_wilkes@fws.gov</a>                                                          | Programmatic          |

\*Cooperative program and pass-through agency for various funding

\*\*Grant with multi-year cycle